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span.at (<http://span.at>) **()**

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Abstract

This paper proposes the standard adds the `at` method to `std::span` class in order to address safety, consistency and PR (public relations) concerns.

Request

```
constexpr reference at(size_type idx) const;
```

Returns a reference to the element at specified location `idx`, with bounds checking.

If `idx` is not within the range of the container, an exception of type `std::out_of_range` is thrown.

Parameters `idx` - index of the element to return

Return value Reference to the requested element.

Exceptions Throws `std::out_of_range` if `idx >= size()`.

Complexity Constant.

Motivation

Safety

This new method is safe in the sense that it has defined behavior instead of undefined behavior. Further, the defined behavior is one that can be caught in the code by catching the exception.

Consistency

The `std::string` ^[1], `std::string_view` ^[2], `std::deque` ^[3], `std::vector` ^[4] and `std::array` ^[5], all have both the unsafe `operator[]` and the safe `at` function.

	<code>operator[]</code>	<code>at()</code>
<code>std::string</code>	✓	✓
<code>std::string_view</code>	✓	✓
<code>std::deque</code>	✓	✓
<code>std::vector</code>	✓	✓
<code>std::array</code>	✓	✓
<code>std::span</code>	✓	✗

Public Relations

c++ keeps giving easy wins to our rivals even though they like to hit below the belt. It is nice when a supporter of a rival language makes an honest comparison.

“In both Rust and C++, there is a method for checked array indexing, and a method for unchecked array indexing. The languages actually agree on this issue. They only disagree about which version gets to be spelled with brackets.” - **Being Fair about Memory Safety and Performance** ^[6]

Unfortunately this isn't totally true.

*“`std::span<T>` **indexing**”* ^[7]

...

“`std::vector` and `std::array` can at least theoretically be used safely because they offer an `at()` method which is bounds checked (in practice I've never seen this done, but you could imagine a project adopting a static analysis tool which simply banned calls to `std::vector<T>::operator[]`). `span` does not offer an `at()` method, or any other method which performs a bounds checked lookup.” ^[7:1]

“Interestingly, both Firefox and Chromium's backports of `std::span` do perform bounds checks in `operator[]`, and thus they'll never be able to safely migrate to `std::span`.” - **Modern C++ Won't Save Us** ^[7:2]

Consequently, the programming community in general are encouraged to ask some tough questions.

1. Why was `span::at()` not provided in C++20 ?
2. Was this an accidental omission or was it deliberate?
3. If deliberate, what was the rationale?
4. If deliberate, are the other `at` functions going to be deprecated?
5. Why was `span::at()` not added in C++23 ?
6. Is it going to be in C++26 ?

Ultimately, this becomes a stereotypical example of how C++ traditionally handles safety. This example gets to be pointed at for years/decades to come. All of this could have been avoided, along with more effort of adding this function individually had more consideration been given valid safety concerns.

Implementation Experience

Both of the `span lite` and `Guidelines Support Library` libraries have this new method implemented for years.

- `span lite`: A single-file header-only version of a C++20-like `span` for C++98, C++11 and later ^[8]
- Guidelines Support Library ^[9]

Likely, there are others too such as “*Firefox and Chromium’s backports of `std::span`*”. ^[7:3]

Summary

Please add the `at` method to `std::span` class in order to address safety, consistency and PR (public relations) concerns. Also keep ones mind open to an `std::expected` version in the future as well as other reasonable safety requests.

References

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